



ANTONY (LEFT) AND
MUKHERJEE

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DELHI | Austerity Choppers

Even Barack Obama junked them because the US Government couldn't afford it. But despite the Indian season of austerity, the UPA Government seems not to want to practice it. With its proposal to replace the existing Mi-17 helicopter fleet for vVIPs with Augusta Westland AW-101 helicopters at a cost of Rs 4,200 crore, it seems like spring is early at home. The proposal to acquire the costly choppers for the Air Force's Communication Squadron that operates the vVIP fleet for the use of the President and the prime minister and senior ministers, has triggered off protests from within the Government. Sources say that even as the proposal is being pushed through the Cabinet Committee on Security, and Defence Minister A.K. Antony is believed to be backing it, it has not gone well with Finance Minister Pranab Mukherjee. The Finance Ministry is objecting not just to the helicopter's high costs but also its procurement through a single vendor, Italian company Finmeccanica. The AW-101 carries around 30 persons but has 10 passengers in its vVIP configuration and three engines for better power and safety. It is hard to find any justification to waste the taxpayer's money for such a purchase, particularly as the Government supposedly says it wants to watch its wallet.

by Saurabh Shukla

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the number of AW-101 helicopters the Government is proposing to buy at a huge cost of Rs 350 crore each.